and contributing to joint operations in regions such as Afghanistan and Kosovo, Erdoğan's disdain for NATO's embrace of human rights and regional policies underscores this tension (Hazir 2022). Despite his criticisms, Erdoğan recognizes NATO's importance to Turkish national security. Turkey's military culture and standards are deeply intertwined with NATO, and its strategic geography places it at the forefront of operations against threats like the Islamic State and as a critical ally in NATO's support for Ukraine against Russian aggression (Kinacioğlu and Gürzel 2013).

Erdoğan has leveraged Turkey's importance within NATO to reshape the alliance to his advantage. For example, tensions flared between Erdoğan and NATO during Sweden and Finland's joint bid to join NATO after Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022.[26] Alarmed by the prospect of Russian expansion, these Nordic nations sought NATO membership to bolster their security. Turkey, however, held up their accession to the bloc, delaying Finland and Sweden's formal acceptance into the group until April 2023 and January 2024 respectively. In doing so, Erdoğan cited grievances over Sweden's past support for Kurdish groups and arms embargoes in the region as well as a series of anti-Muslim protests that Erdoğan condemned as inflammatory.[27]

To secure Erdoğan's approval, NATO and its member states employed a mix of appeasement and strategic negotiation. The alliance often softened its stance to retain Turkey's cooperation.[28] For instance, NATO appointed a Turkish assistant secretary-general in 2010 to address concerns about representation and frequently emphasized terrorism in its internal communications to align with Turkish priorities.[29] Regarding Sweden's membership, NATO facilitated a series of concessions: The United States advanced plans to sell Turkey forty F-16 fighter jets and modernization kits, Sweden pledged to reinvigorate Turkey's EU membership bid, and Sweden and Finland agreed to strengthen anti-terror laws and extradite individuals whom Turkey identified as terrorists. NATO itself adopted a more robust counterterrorism stance, appointing a special coordinator for these efforts.[30] Such moves went beyond paying lip service to Erdoğan's foreign policy priorities.

Negotiations over these items often took place in private, away from public scrutiny. At a pivotal 2023 NATO summit, NATO Secretary General Jens Stoltenberg held private meetings with Erdoğan and other leaders who